

RABBIT · *ORYCTOLAGUS CUNICULUS*

Keep your rabbit the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the space standard the pet-store hutch misses, unlimited hay and why it is the whole diet, GI stasis triage, and the routines that carry a rabbit through 8 to 12 years.

22 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
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SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Housing & Space	5
Flooring, Litter Training & Bunny-Proofing	6
Handling & Building Trust	7
Diet & Feeding by Life Stage	8
Common Mistakes & Enrichment	9

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & the Right Vet	10
GI Stasis, the Emergency	11
Dental Disease & Flystrike	12
Snuffles, Uterine Cancer & Other Conditions	13

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Diet Targets	14
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	15

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	16
First 30 Days Checklist	17
Symptom Quick Reference	18
Daily & Weekly Routine	19
Owner Log	20
Enrichment Checklist	21

REFERENCE

Glossary	22
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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying anything. Two decisions here are expensive to reverse: the space you commit to, and whether you get one rabbit or a bonded pair. Both are covered on pages 5 and 9, and both have research behind them. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16, and budget the spay or neuter separately, because it is the line item people most often forget.

If your rabbit is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Diet Targets on page 14 to audit what you have, and page 10 if anything seems off. If your rabbit has not eaten or produced droppings for 8 hours or more, stop reading and call a rabbit-savvy vet today. Page 11 explains why that number is so much shorter than it is for other pets.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Diet Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 18: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 21: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Rabbit welfare standards have shifted a long way from the wire hutch, and most of what is still sold for rabbits reflects the old picture. This package uses current House Rabbit Society space guidance and the peer-reviewed companionship and run-access research on pages 5 and 9, cross-checked against veterinary sources rather than packaging.

FIND THE VET BEFORE YOU NEED ONE

Rabbits need a rabbit-savvy exotic vet, not a standard small-animal clinic. A vet unfamiliar with rabbit physiology can genuinely miss or mishandle the conditions in Section 03. Find one now, through a rabbit rescue or the House Rabbit Society, and write the number on page 15.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Oryctolagus cuniculus</i> , the domestic rabbit
Adult size	Highly variable by breed, 2.5 to 20+ lbs. Over 300 breeds recognized
Captive lifespan	7 to 10 years indoors, some past 12. Outdoor rabbits average closer to 2
Native range	Iberian Peninsula originally; grassland, meadow, and forest edge
Diet type	Hindgut-fermenting herbivore. Grass hay is 80 to 85% of the diet
Space minimum	8 sq ft enclosure plus 24 sq ft exercise space, 5+ hours a day
Social needs	Highly social. A neutered, bonded pair is the evidence-backed default
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate; physically fragile, and most prefer not to be lifted
Desexing	Strongly recommended. Up to 80% of unspayed does aged 5+ develop uterine cancer

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$150 to \$600 for an exercise pen, litter box, dishes, hay feeder, nail clippers, carrier, and bunny-proofing. Spay or neuter is separate at \$150 to \$500+.

Monthly ongoing

\$60 to \$100 for hay, pellets, fresh vegetables, and litter. Annual total lands around \$500 to \$800 after the first year, which runs \$1,000 to \$1,500.

KEEP A REAL EMERGENCY FUND

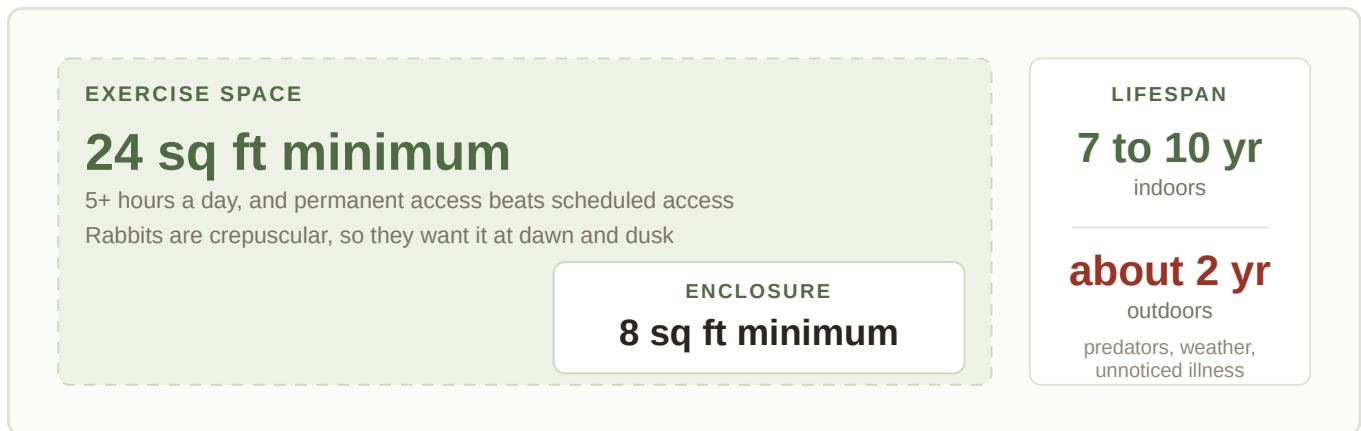
A GI stasis workup alone can exceed \$1,500, and rabbits hide illness well, so when something goes wrong it tends to go wrong fast. Keep \$500 to \$1,000 set aside separately from the routine budget.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Rabbits eliminate almost reflexively while they eat, which is why putting hay directly over the litter box does most of the litter training for you.
- Cecotropes, the soft nutrient-dense droppings a rabbit produces and eats directly, usually overnight, are a real part of digestion rather than an accident. They recover B vitamins the gut bacteria made on the first pass.
- Adopting is often the cheapest route overall. Fees of \$25 to \$100 frequently include the spay or neuter plus an initial vet check, which would cost several times that separately.
- They are crepuscular, most active at dawn and dusk, which is exactly when a rabbit confined to a hutch most wants the run.

Housing & space

If you have seen a small wire hutch marketed as a rabbit cage, it is worth knowing plainly: current welfare standards consider that size inadequate. The House Rabbit Society recommends at least 8 square feet of enclosure combined with at least 24 square feet of exercise space for one to two rabbits, with a minimum of 5 hours a day to run and play. In practice that means a large foldable metal exercise pen, 4 ft by 4 ft or bigger, is the realistic standard, not a small cage a rabbit is occasionally let out of.



The enclosure is a bedroom, not the house. Figures cover one to two rabbits; a bonded pair still needs the run.
Avoid aquariums and solid-walled enclosures: poor ventilation lets ammonia build up.

SPACE SHOWS UP IN THE BLOODWORK, NOT JUST THE BEHAVIOR

A study of pair-housed pet rabbits found that run access, hutch size, and time of day all affected welfare-relevant behavior *and* fecal corticosterone. Space is not a nicety here, it registers in a stress hormone metabolite.

Indoors is strongly the better choice

The lifespan gap above is the whole argument. Outdoor rabbits face predators, extreme weather, and health problems that go unnoticed without daily close contact, and flystrike (page 12) is overwhelmingly an outdoor risk. If you are deciding where a rabbit will live, indoors is the option that actually protects it.

Flooring, litter training & bunny-proofing

Flooring

Skip wire flooring entirely. It contributes directly to sore hocks (page 13), which is a painful, slow-healing condition and a fully preventable one. Vinyl or linoleum over plywood, washable rugs, or fleece all give better traction and are easier on a rabbit's feet. A waterproof tarp under the whole setup protects your actual floor from the inevitable accidents.

Litter training, which is easier than it sounds

Rabbits tend to eliminate while they eat, so the trick is putting hay directly in or right over the litter box. That alone does most of the training work, because you are routing an existing behavior rather than teaching a new one. Use a large cat-litter-box-style container, not the small corner boxes marketed specifically for rabbits, and fill it with paper-based or compressed wood-pellet litter.

NEVER USE

Clumping cat litter, which causes serious problems if ingested, or pine and cedar shavings, which release aromatic oils that irritate a rabbit's respiratory system. Both are still sold near the rabbit supplies.

IF LITTER TRAINING ISN'T WORKING

Spaying or neutering meaningfully improves litter habits, and an intact rabbit marking territory is the most common reason training stalls. If you are fighting the litter box with an intact rabbit, that is usually the underlying reason rather than a training failure.

Bunny-proofing the run space

- Cover or reroute every electrical cable within reach. Chewing through a live cable is the single most common serious household accident for a free-range rabbit.
- Block gaps behind and under furniture, appliances, and cabinets. A rabbit will fit somewhere you assumed it could not.
- Move houseplants out of reach and check them against a toxic plant list before assuming they are safe.
- Protect baseboards and carpet edges, or accept they will be chewed. Offering cardboard and untreated willow gives the behavior a legal outlet.
- Keep the space non-slip. Rabbits scramble on smooth floors, and a slip can injure a spine that is already fragile.

Temperature and ventilation

Rabbits tolerate cold far better than heat, and heat stress is a real risk above roughly 80°F. Keep them out of direct afternoon sun, provide shade and airflow, and never use a solid-walled enclosure where ammonia from urine can build up. If a room is comfortable for you in a jumper, it is comfortable for a rabbit.

Handling & building trust

Rabbits are more physically fragile than most first-time owners expect. They have delicate spines and powerful hind legs, and that combination means an unsupported or panicked rabbit can genuinely injure itself trying to escape your grip. Getting this right matters more here than with almost any other common pet.

WHY SUPPORT IS THE WHOLE THING

A rabbit struggling against an unsupported hold can fracture its own lumbar spine. The strength of the hind legs works against it in exactly the wrong way when the body is not fully supported. This is not a handling preference, it is the single most important thing to get right with this species.

The correct way to pick one up

Support the chest with one hand, positioned just behind the front legs, and the hindquarters with the other, simultaneously. Lift with both regions supported at once, hold the rabbit close against your body rather than out at arm's length, and keep sessions low to the ground. If the rabbit struggles, lower it back down immediately rather than trying to maintain your grip. Never lift a rabbit by the ears, and never rely on the scruff alone to carry its weight.

The "football hold" that vets use is worth learning: tuck the rabbit's head into the crook of your elbow with its body supported along your forearm. It is a genuinely low-stress way to carry a rabbit securely.

SKIP TRANCING

You may see advice about flipping a rabbit onto its back to calm it. Don't. Research measuring rabbits in that position found significant increases in respiration, heart rate, and stress hormone levels. The stillness is closer to freezing in fear than to relaxing, which is exactly why the myth lasted so long: it looks calm from the outside.

Building trust

Most rabbits are calmest with all four feet on the ground, and many never come to enjoy being picked up even once they fully trust you. That is normal, and it is not a failure. Build trust at floor level instead: sit or lie down at the rabbit's height, hand-feed greens, and let the rabbit choose to approach rather than reaching in to grab it. Over time that earns you a rabbit that is relaxed around you even if actual pick-ups stay rare.

Signs to put the rabbit down

Thumping a hind foot, a tense rigid body, wide eyes, fast shallow breathing, teeth grinding (a pain signal here, not contentment), freezing in place, or bolting and kicking. Set the rabbit down in one smooth motion, in a straight line rather than dropping it, and give it space. When freezing or constant hiding becomes a rabbit's normal state rather than a reaction to being handled, that is a longer-running problem worth addressing at the housing level.

Diet & feeding by life stage

Unlimited grass hay is the foundation at every adult stage, available around the clock. It is not filler: it keeps the gut moving and wears down teeth that grow continuously for the rabbit's whole life. Pellets are the smallest part of the diet, not the base.

LIFE STAGE	HAY	PELLETS & FRESH FOOD
Juvenile (7 weeks to 7 months)	Unlimited alfalfa	Unlimited alfalfa-based pellets; vegetables added gradually from about 3 months, one item at a time
Transition (about 4 to 6 months)	Alfalfa phased out for grass hay	Pellet portions reduced gradually over several weeks
Adult (7 months to about 5 years)	Unlimited grass hay, 80 to 85% of the diet	Roughly 1/8 to 1/4 cup high-fiber timothy pellets per 5 to 6 lbs; at least 3 varieties of leafy greens daily
Senior (6+ years)	Unlimited grass hay continues	Alfalfa may return if underweight; more individualized, vet-guided feeding

Sources vary on exact pellet and vegetable amounts, and the honest answer is that they scale with body weight and condition rather than landing on one number. Check yours with a rabbit-savvy vet. Fresh water is available at all times at every stage, by bottle or bowl.

Grass hay, not alfalfa, for adults

Timothy, orchard, oat, or brome. Alfalfa's extra calcium and calories are for babies, juveniles, pregnant or nursing does, and underweight seniors. Fed to a healthy adult it contributes to obesity and bladder sludge.

Plain pellets, not a mix

A fresh, high-fiber, plain timothy-based pellet. Colorful mixes with seeds, nuts, or dried fruit are linked to obesity and dental disease, because a rabbit eats the sweet parts and leaves the fiber.

Greens and treats

Leafy greens make up the bulk of the fresh portion: romaine, cilantro, parsley, basil, arugula, bok choy, carrot tops. Offer at least three varieties daily and introduce new items one at a time so you can spot soft stool. Non-leafy vegetables like bell pepper, cucumber, and carrot go in smaller amounts, since they are higher in sugar and starch than their reputation suggests. Fruit is a treat at roughly 1 to 2 tablespoons once or twice a week, not daily, and carrots are a treat too despite the cartoons.

NEVER FEED

Avocado, which can cause respiratory distress and fatal heart failure. Chocolate. Onions, garlic, and chives, which carry hemolytic anemia risk. Rhubarb, high in oxalic acid and linked to kidney damage. Iceberg lettuce is not toxic but is nutritionally near-empty and causes digestive upset in quantity. Skip bread, crackers, cereal, and especially commercial yogurt drops, which are explicitly inappropriate despite being sold as rabbit treats.

CHANGE FOOD SLOWLY, ALWAYS

A sudden switch of hay, pellet brand, or vegetables can disrupt the cecal bacteria and trigger soft stool or GI stasis. There is no gut-loading or supplement dusting in rabbit care; the closest equivalent is a gradual transition over a week or more.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Treating a hutch as housing rather than as a bedroom inside a much larger run.
- Keeping a rabbit alone and expecting toys to close the gap. The research measured that gap, and toys are not what changed it.
- Overfeeding pellets relative to hay, which drives both obesity and the dental disease on page 12.
- Waiting out a skipped meal. In this species that is the emergency, not a quiet day.
- Wire flooring, which causes sore hocks.
- Scheduling exercise for the household's convenience rather than at dawn and dusk when a crepuscular animal actually wants it.
- Skipping the spay or neuter, which forfeits both the litter training benefit and the uterine cancer protection on page 13.
- Treating digging and chewing as behavior problems rather than as needs without an outlet.

A COMPANION BEATS EVERYTHING ELSE YOU COULD BUY

In privately owned rabbits, solitary animals showed significantly less behavioral diversity and more awake inactivity than socially housed ones. Socially housed rabbits were more active. The same work found a larger age difference between paired rabbits was associated with a lower friendship index, which is a practical steer when choosing a companion.

Enrichment, by priority

1. A neutered, bonded companion

Close in age. Neuter both first, and bond them properly over weeks rather than putting two rabbits in a room. A single rabbit with an attentive owner is a compromise, not an equivalent.

3. Unlimited hay, made to take time

Stuff it into cardboard tubes, hang it in bundles, put it in the litter tray, scatter greens through it. Hay is the diet, the dental mechanism, and the enrichment all at once.

5. Platforms and cover

An elevated platform let group-housed rabbits move up and down, rest more comfortably, and increase exploratory behavior. Somewhere to get on and somewhere to get under, because the choice is the enrichment.

2. Permanent run access

Or free range of a rabbit-proofed room. Permanent beats scheduled: a rabbit let out for an hour a day spends the other 23 confined, and the corticosterone finding is pointing straight at this.

4. A dig box

These are burrowing animals. A large container of safe soil, shredded paper, or hay gives digging an outlet, and a rabbit with nowhere to dig will pick somewhere you would rather it did not.

6. Chewing and shredding, then novelty

Bamboo chew sticks, untreated willow, plain cardboard. Novel objects come last and are the cheap part.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

SAME-DAY VET IF YOU SEE
No food or droppings for 8 hours or more · a bloated or tense abdomen · visible fly eggs or maggots in the fur · open-mouth breathing or persistent discharge · sudden lethargy or hiding · audible teeth grinding with a hunched posture · droppings that are small, misshapen, or strung together with fur

Rabbits hide illness, and the clock is short

As a prey species, a rabbit's instinct is to conceal weakness, so by the time something is obvious it is usually well underway. Combine that with a gut that needs near-constant throughput and you get the defining feature of rabbit health: the safe window is measured in hours rather than days. A cat or a dog can comfortably skip a meal. A rabbit that skips one has started a clock.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ When the rabbit last ate, and what it last ate willingly
- ☐ When you last saw normal droppings, and what they looked like
- ☐ Current weight and the trend from your log
- ☐ Any recent change: diet, housing, household, or a new pet
- ☐ Whether the rabbit is spayed or neutered, and at what age
- ☐ Vaccination status, including RHDV2

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Soft tooth-purring while being stroked, a contented sound	Harsh, audible teeth grinding, which is a pain signal
Eating cecotropes directly, usually overnight	Uneaten cecotropes stuck to the fur or the floor, often a diet or weight problem
Loose fur and heavier grooming during a molt	Bald patches, scabs, or fur strung through the droppings
Flopping over dramatically on one side to sleep	Lying stretched out and unresponsive, or hunched and pressing the belly down

GI stasis, the emergency

8 HOURS IS THE NUMBER

A rabbit that has not eaten or passed droppings in 8 hours or more needs a same-day visit to a rabbit-savvy vet. Not tomorrow, not after a night of monitoring. GI stasis can turn life-threatening within 24 to 48 hours of onset.

What it actually is

Rabbits are hindgut fermenters, and their digestive system depends on continuous movement to process a high-fiber diet. When gut motility slows or stops, gas builds up, painful bloating follows, and the balance of gut bacteria can shift dangerously. This is not a dramatic injury or an exotic disease, it is the gut simply stopping, and it kills more pet rabbits than almost anything else.

Triggers

TRIGGER	WHY IT MATTERS
Low-fiber diet	Insufficient hay slows motility over time. The single biggest risk factor
Stress	A loud environment, a new pet, or a vet visit can be enough
Dehydration	Reduces gut lubrication and motility directly
Dental pain	Makes eating uncomfortable, and reduced intake alone starts it
Pain from any other cause	A rabbit in pain stops eating, which begins the same loop
Fur ingested during a heavy molt	Swallowed fur plus dry gut contents can form a hard-to-pass mass

Early warning signs

Reduced or absent fecal output, the earliest and most reliable sign. Smaller, oddly shaped, or fur-strung droppings before a full stop. Picking at food without fully refusing. A hunched posture with the belly pulled in. Harsh, audible teeth grinding, distinct from the soft tooth-purring of a relaxed rabbit.

DO NOT TRY PINEAPPLE JUICE OR GAS DROPS

Outdated home remedies with no reliable evidence behind them, and relying on them spends the time that matters most. Treatment is veterinary: fluids, pain control, motility medication, and finding the trigger. Syringe-feeding a critical care formula is often part of recovery but should be vet-guided, since force-feeding a rabbit with a genuine blockage can make things worse.

PREVENTION, AND THE ODDS

Unlimited grass hay at 80% or more of the diet is the single most protective habit available, alongside fresh water and a daily glance at the litter box. Roughly 70% of rabbits recover with prompt treatment, and delayed cases can need days of hospitalization.

Dental disease & flystrike

Dental disease

Cause: rabbit teeth grow continuously, as much as 4 to 5 inches a year, and it is the side-to-side grinding of long-strand fiber that wears them down. A pellet-heavy, hay-light diet does not do that work, so teeth overgrow and molar spurs form against the cheek or tongue. **Signs:** drooling, dropping food while trying to eat, a preference for softer foods, weight loss, and watery eyes when overgrown roots press on tear ducts. **Diagnosis:** an oral exam, usually with a scope, since molar spurs sit too far back to see from the front. **Response:** a sedated trim, often repeated. **Prevention:** a properly hay-based diet, which is the whole mechanism.

WHY DENTAL DISEASE SHOWS UP AS GI STASIS

The two are linked more often than owners expect. Painful teeth mean reduced eating, and reduced eating is exactly what starts stasis. A rabbit having repeat stasis episodes usually needs a dental exam, not just symptomatic treatment for the gut.

Flystrike

Cause: flies lay eggs on soiled or damp fur, most often around the rear end, and the maggots that hatch feed on the rabbit's tissue. **Signs:** visible eggs that look like small grains of rice, damp or matted fur, a foul smell, and a rabbit that is suddenly lethargic or restless. **Speed:** it can kill within 24 to 48 hours. **Response:** an immediate emergency vet visit, not a home clean-up. **Risk factors:** outdoor housing, hot weather, obesity or mobility problems that stop a rabbit grooming its own rear, dental disease, diarrhea, and urine-soaked fur that is not caught promptly.

THE DAILY CHECK THAT PREVENTS IT

In warm weather, check your rabbit's rear end and underside every single day, and twice a day for any rabbit that is overweight, elderly, or has mobility problems. This is thirty seconds, and it is the difference between a wash and a fatal emergency.

Snuffles, uterine cancer & other conditions

Respiratory infection ("snuffles")

Cause: often *Pasteurella multocida*, with poor ventilation, ammonia build-up, and dusty bedding as contributing factors.

Signs: eye or nasal discharge, sneezing, and crusty matted fur on the front paws from a rabbit wiping its own nose

repeatedly. That paw sign is the one owners most often notice first. **Response:** a vet, since this rarely resolves alone and can become chronic. **Prevention:** ventilation, clean litter, and no solid-walled enclosures.

Uterine cancer

Risk: up to 80% of unsprayed does aged 5 and older develop uterine cancer, with risk beginning to climb from around age two. That is one of the highest documented cancer rates in any commonly kept pet. **Signs:** blood in the urine, reduced appetite, lethargy, and sometimes a palpable abdominal mass, but often nothing obvious until it is advanced. **Prevention:** spaying, ideally well before the risk starts climbing. This is why rabbit-savvy vets treat desexing as close to routine rather than optional, and it is also why a spay costs more than a neuter: it is a more invasive procedure.

A few more worth knowing

- **E. cuniculi:** a parasite that can cause head tilt, hind limb weakness, and contributes to recurrent GI stasis episodes. Treatable, and worth testing for when neurological signs appear.
- **Sore hocks (pododermatitis):** pressure sores on the underside of the hind feet, from wire flooring, inadequate bedding, or damp litter. Slow to heal, so prevention through flooring choice (page 6) is the real answer.
- **Bladder sludge or stones:** related to calcium in the diet, and one of the specific reasons adult rabbits are kept off alfalfa.
- **RHDV2:** rabbit hemorrhagic disease virus, a fatal viral disease. Annual vaccination is recommended in the US and is genuinely worth discussing with your vet rather than treating as an optional extra.

THE PATTERN ACROSS THIS WHOLE SECTION

Hay prevents the dental disease that causes the stasis. Desexing prevents the cancer and improves the litter habits. Flooring prevents the sore hocks. Indoor housing prevents most flystrike. Almost everything in Section 03 traces back to a decision made in Section 02.

Setup checklist & diet targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Exercise pen, 4 ft by 4 ft or larger, 8 sq ft minimum enclosure
- ☐ Non-wire flooring: vinyl, washable rug, or fleece
- ☐ Large cat-style litter box, not a corner box
- ☐ Hay rack or feeder positioned over the litter box
- ☐ Hides and a platform to get up onto
- ☐ Nail clippers and a brush for molts
- ☐ 24 sq ft or more of exercise space, ideally permanent access
- ☐ Waterproof tarp under the whole setup
- ☐ Paper-based or compressed wood-pellet litter
- ☐ Heavy food dish and a water bowl or bottle
- ☐ Dig box, chew sticks, and cardboard
- ☐ Carrier, plus a rabbit-savvy vet's number

Diet targets

COMPONENT	TARGET
Grass hay (adult)	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet
Alfalfa hay	Juveniles, pregnant or nursing does, underweight seniors only
Pellets (adult)	About 1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lbs of body weight
Leafy greens	At least 3 varieties daily, scaled to body weight
Non-leafy vegetables	Small amounts, higher in sugar and starch
Fruit and treats	1 to 2 tablespoons, once or twice a week
Water	Always available, bottle or bowl
Diet changes	Gradual, over a week or more

Before your rabbit comes home

- ☐ Run space bunny-proofed: cables covered, gaps blocked, plants moved
- ☐ Same hay and pellets the rescue or breeder was using
- ☐ Litter box set up with hay over it from day one
- ☐ Rabbit-savvy exotic vet identified, with their emergency hours noted
- ☐ Spay or neuter booked, or confirmed already done
- ☐ Emergency fund of \$500 to \$1,000 set aside

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A RABBIT-SAVVY VET TODAY IF

No food or droppings for 8+ hours · a bloated or tense abdomen · fly eggs or maggots in the fur · open-mouth breathing or persistent discharge · sudden lethargy or hiding · harsh teeth grinding with a hunched posture · droppings small, misshapen, or fur-strung · head tilt or loss of balance

READING	TARGET
No eating or droppings, act by	8 hours
Fasting beyond this risks fatty liver	24 hours
Hay share of the diet	80 to 85%, unlimited
Pellets, adult	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lbs daily
Enclosure and exercise space	8 sq ft plus 24 sq ft, 5+ hours a day
Heat stress risk above	About 80°F
Wellness exams	Twice a year with a rabbit-savvy vet
Flystrike checks in warm weather	Daily, twice daily for at-risk rabbits

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

When the rabbit last ate and last produced normal droppings, what the droppings looked like, current weight and the trend from your log, spay or neuter status, RHDV2 vaccination status, and anything that changed in the last few days.

MY VET

Practice: _____ Phone: _____

Out of hours: _____ Nearest 24hr exotic: _____

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Adoption fee (often includes spay/neuter and a vet check)	\$25 to \$100
Exercise pen (foldable metal x-pen)	\$40 to \$100
Litter box, large cat-style	\$5 to \$15
Food and water dishes	\$10 to \$20
Nail clippers	About \$10
Hay feeder, carrier, bunny-proofing supplies	Remainder of the range
Total initial supplies	\$150 to \$600
Spay or neuter, budgeted separately	\$150 to \$500+ (neuter \$200 to \$300; low-cost programs from about \$139)
Hay (monthly)	\$20 to \$40
Pellets (monthly)	\$5 to \$15
Fresh vegetables (monthly)	\$15 to \$50
Litter (monthly)	\$15 to \$25
Monthly ongoing	\$60 to \$100
Routine vet visit, twice yearly recommended	\$60 to \$100 per visit
Annual total after year one	\$500 to \$800
First year, including setup and desexing	\$1,000 to \$1,500

THE NUMBER THAT CATCHES PEOPLE OFF GUARD

A GI stasis workup alone can exceed \$1,500. Rabbits need an exotic or rabbit-savvy vet, which costs more than a standard clinic, and they hide illness well enough that problems arrive already advanced. Keep \$500 to \$1,000 as an emergency fund, separate from the monthly budget.

ADOPTING IS USUALLY THE CHEAPEST ROUTE

A \$25 to \$100 adoption fee that already includes the spay or neuter plus an initial vet check beats the pet store on total cost by several hundred dollars, before you account for getting an adult rabbit whose temperament you can actually assess.

First 30 days checklist

Week 1

- ☐ Keep the same hay and pellets the rescue or breeder was using. No diet change yet
- ☐ Check the litter box daily for normal droppings. This is your early warning system
- ☐ Sit at floor level near the pen without reaching in, several times a day
- ☐ Confirm hay is over the litter box and topped up constantly

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Book a wellness exam with a rabbit-savvy vet, and ask about RHDV2 vaccination
- ☐ Begin hand-feeding greens at floor level; still no lifting unless necessary
- ☐ Introduce new leafy greens one at a time, watching for soft stool
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20, including weight and daily fecal output

Week 4

- ☐ Begin any hay or pellet transition now, gradually over a week or more
- ☐ Review the weight trend and the fecal output pattern from your log
- ☐ Extend run time toward permanent access if you started with sessions
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21, one at a time

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book the spay or neuter if it is not already done
- ☐ If you plan on a companion, start the bonding conversation with your rescue now. Bonding takes weeks
- ☐ Learn your rabbit's normal fecal output well enough to notice a change
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 21

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
No eating or droppings for 8+ hours	GI stasis	Same-day vet, do not wait (page 11)
Small, misshapen, or fur-strung droppings	Early stasis, or a molt	Vet contact today; brush during molts (page 11)
Hunched posture, harsh teeth grinding	Abdominal pain	Same-day vet (page 11)
Drooling, dropping food, weight loss	Dental disease or molar spurs	Vet dental exam under scope (page 12)
Damp, matted rear fur, rice-like eggs	Flystrike	Emergency vet now (page 12)
Sneezing, eye or nose discharge, crusty front paws	Snuffles	Vet, does not clear alone (page 13)
Head tilt, loss of balance	E. cuniculi or an ear infection	Vet promptly (page 13)
Blood in urine, lethargy, unspayed female	Uterine disease	Vet promptly (page 13)
Sore, bald, or scabbed hind feet	Sore hocks	Change flooring; vet if broken skin (page 13)
Uneaten cecotropes stuck to fur	Too many pellets, or overweight	Cut pellets, raise hay share (page 8)
Panting, lying flat, hot ears	Heat stress	Cool the room gradually, vet if unresponsive (page 6)
Thumping, freezing, or constant hiding	Stress or too little space	Review space and handling (pages 5 and 7)

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Top up hay so it is never empty, and refresh the pile in the litter box
- ☐ Fresh water, and scrub the bowl or bottle spout
- ☐ Measured pellets and at least three varieties of leafy greens
- ☐ Check the litter box: how many droppings, what shape, what size
- ☐ Run time at dawn and dusk if access is not permanent
- ☐ In warm weather, check the rear end and underside for flystrike risk

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh and log, on the same day each week
- ☐ Full litter box change and a wipe-down of the enclosure
- ☐ Check nails, and clip if needed
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one enrichment item
- ☐ Run a hand over the body: lumps, scabs, sore hocks, matted fur

Monthly

- ☐ Deep clean the enclosure and wash fleece or rugs
- ☐ Restock hay before you run low, never after
- ☐ Re-check bunny-proofing: new cables, new gaps, new plants
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends rather than single days

Seasonal and yearly

- ☐ Brush daily through a heavy molt, since swallowed fur feeds into stasis
- ☐ Watch heat closely in summer; rabbits handle cold far better than heat
- ☐ Twice-yearly wellness exams, and annual RHDV2 vaccination

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	DROPPINGS	APPETITE	HAY EATEN	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

Fecal output is the earliest and most reliable warning sign this species gives you, and it only works as a signal if you know what normal looks like for your rabbit. A written baseline turns "that seems like fewer droppings" into something you can actually act on at hour eight rather than hour twenty.

Vet & vaccination log

DATE	REASON OR VACCINE	NEXT DUE

Weight trend

MONTH	WEIGHT	BODY CONDITION NOTES

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ A neutered, bonded companion, close in age
- ☐ Permanent run access, or a rabbit-proofed room
- ☐ Hay presented so it takes time: tubes, bundles, a rack over the litter tray
- ☐ Dig box with safe soil, shredded paper, or hay
- ☐ A platform to get up onto, and cover to get under
- ☐ Chew and shred material: bamboo, untreated willow, plain cardboard

Monthly review

- ☐ Scatter greens through hay or a snuffle mat rather than serving in a bowl
- ☐ Move or refresh one platform, tunnel, or hide
- ☐ Check the dig box still has something worth digging in
- ☐ Watch for awake inactivity: a still rabbit is not automatically a content one

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't keep a rabbit alone and expect toys to close the gap, since the research measured that gap and toys were not what changed it. Don't treat a hutch as housing. Don't schedule exercise for the household's convenience when the animal is crepuscular. Don't pair rabbits without neutering both first. And don't treat digging as a behavior problem.

Enrichment log

DATE	CHANGE MADE	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

GI stasis	Gastrointestinal stasis: the gut slowing or stopping. The most common life-threatening emergency in pet rabbits.
Hindgut fermenter	An animal that digests fiber in the cecum, after the small intestine, which is why constant throughput matters so much.
Cecotropes	Soft, nutrient-rich droppings a rabbit produces and eats directly, usually overnight. A normal part of digestion.
Bruxism	Teeth grinding. Soft tooth-purring is contentment; harsh, audible grinding is pain.
Molar spur	A sharp point on an overgrown back tooth that cuts the cheek or tongue. Not visible from the front of the mouth.
Flystrike	Myiasis: fly eggs laid on soiled fur hatching into maggots. Can kill within 24 to 48 hours.
Snuffles	Upper respiratory infection, often <i>Pasteurella multocida</i> .
Pododermatitis	Sore hocks: pressure sores on the underside of the hind feet, usually from wire flooring or damp bedding.
E. cuniculi	<i>Encephalitozoon cuniculi</i> , a parasite that can cause head tilt and recurrent stasis episodes.
RHDV2	Rabbit hemorrhagic disease virus type 2. Fatal, and vaccinated against annually in the US.
Crepuscular	Most active at dawn and dusk, which is when a rabbit most wants access to its run.
Bonding	The weeks-long process of introducing two neutered rabbits so they live together as a pair.

Compiled from veterinary and rabbit welfare sources, including House Rabbit Society space guidance and the peer-reviewed companionship, run-access, and platform research cited on pages 5 and 9, and cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for a rabbit-savvy exotic veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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